

KEEP THE PROOF — VERSION 2

Plain-language pass

Prepared for Temidayo Afonja, The Density Group. September 18, 2026.

A focused review against one test: does the reader feel the ordinary problem, in plain words, before the product names its system? The rule applied throughout is ordinary language first, product terminology second, with terms such as professional record, evidence, corroboration, and Proof Line used only after the underlying problem is understood. The broader job of Keep the Proof is preserved: it still captures contribution, judgment, decisions, prevention, scope, evidence, and corroboration so the reader builds an accurate record over time. It is not reduced to defensive paper-trail documentation.

Review only. No final production PDF generated. No LEGAL REVIEW REQUIRED placeholder removed. No website or Starter change.

1. What the test found

The macro flow already leads with recognition. The first body prose (Welcome) opens on the ordinary problem, "Most people do excellent work and remember almost none of it clearly," and the recognition page and the two doors come before any framework. Most section openers also lead with the ordinary problem before naming a tool (for example, "A record does not fail because people lack discipline. It fails because nothing reminds them to open it," before the event-capture idea; "Most meaningful work is shared, and shared work creates a recording problem," before separating team from self).

Two early places named the product's term before the plain problem had fully landed. Both are now fixed. No other place in the manuscript introduces a product term cold.

2. Term-by-term audit

For each product term: where the reader first meets it in the body, whether the ordinary problem is established first, and the verdict after this pass.

- Professional record. First body use was the Part One opening question ("how much of your professional record would disappear with it?"). The recognition page precedes it, but the hook itself led with the term. FIXED: the hook now reads "how much of the record of your work

would disappear with it?", plain language, before the term is used as a label later in Part One. Verdict: ordinary first.

- The underlying problem, in the reader's own words. The recognition page listed situations but did not state the plain internal thought beneath them. ADDED: "Underneath all of them is the same quiet thought: I know I did good work, and now I cannot quite lay my hands on the details... You just want the truth of what you did, and the judgment and the decisions inside it, to still be there when you reach for it." This lands the ordinary recognition, and keeps the broader job in view, before any terminology. Verdict: ordinary first, and not reduced to receipts.
 - Evidence. First meaningful use is the "what a professional record is" page and the claim-example-evidence-corroboration page, both after the Welcome, the recognition page, the opening question, and "why a record goes missing." The hierarchy page motivates before defining ("the word proof means different things to different readers"). Verdict: ordinary problem established first. No change needed.
 - Corroboration. Introduced on the hierarchy page (Part One) with its plain meaning attached ("a former colleague who observed the work"), and taught in Part Four under the ordinary heading "Who could confirm this," which opens on the plain problem (institutions forget, people remember) before naming corroboration. Verdict: ordinary first. No change needed.
 - Proof Line. First appears in Your First 60 Minutes and is defined in Part Five as "a single, plain-language sentence that carries the most useful parts of an entry," well after the reader has recognized the problem and captured real work. Verdict: ordinary first. No change needed.
 - Capture, Clarify, Carry. Plain verbs, introduced in "How to use this guide" after the recognition page and the two doors. Verdict: acceptable; they are ordinary words, not jargon, and follow recognition.
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3. Edits made

1. Part One, opening question. "how much of your professional record would disappear with it?" changed to "how much of the record of your work would disappear with it?"
2. Front matter, "Why you might be here." A plain-language recognition line was added after the situations and before any framework, naming the ordinary thought beneath every situation and keeping the broader job (truth of the work, plus the judgment and decisions inside it) in view.

Both edits move ordinary language ahead of product terminology without changing the approved architecture, the cover positioning, or any boundary.

4. Guardrails held

- The product is not narrowed to receipts or a defensive paper trail. The added recognition line explicitly names judgment and decisions, not just documents, and the manuscript's broader job (contribution, judgment, prevention, scope, evidence, corroboration) is unchanged.
- The approved cover positioning is untouched: "A guided system for building your professional record" remains the descriptor. The plain-language rule applies to the body flow, not the cover title.
- No new claims, no legal changes, no terminology removed. "Professional record," "evidence," "corroboration," and "Proof Line" all remain; they now consistently arrive after the reader recognizes the plain problem.

END OF PLAIN-LANGUAGE PASS